

A draft of this assignment was prepared by Kristen Brookes, Writing Associate, and adapted into this handout by Professor Wagaman. The original article it was designed for was different, but the overall structure of the assignment and learning outcomes from it are the same with the new articles.

Consider the article you read for the week. We will be focusing on the *structure* of the paper, on the *purpose* of different sections, on the writer's *guiding voice*, and on the relationship between the writer and the *audience*. We can also look at how *citation* is employed.

Work in your groups to complete the sections below. At times, we'll stop for class discussion.

I. Understanding Sections

Each of your articles has many different sections. Some are key sections (the main ones), while others are subsections of those.

How many key sections do you find in your paper?

Pick 2 key sections that you want to explore as a group. For each chosen section, fill out the chart below. Write in one column, in sentence form, what the section is saying (the main idea). In the second column write *why* it is saying it. In other words, what is the *function* of each section? As you think about a section's function or purpose, think about the audience. What does the writer want their writing to *do* to or for the reader?

Key Section	Number of Subsections	Main Idea	Why

II. Signposts.

Look at the first sentences (up to a paragraph) in your chosen sections, and another section or two.

Are the first sentences of these sections working to guide the reader through the paper? If you just read the first sentences of each section, would you be able to see the shape of the argument/paper?

Are there sections where you feel a better signpost could have been laid? Give an example of a potential improvement for one section. (You may have to look at multiple sections.)

From section to section, as well as within sections, think from the point of view of a writer writing to communicate to an audience. For example, *when* does the reader need to know *what*? What does the writer tell the reader when, and *why*? (Reflect)

III. Figures and Tables. Pick two figures or tables as a group to consider for this section.

Which Figure / Table	For each selected figure or table, tell <i>why</i> it is included and <i>how</i> the writer helps the reader understand <i>what</i> the figure or table is <i>saying</i> , as well as what it is <i>doing</i> .

--	--

How much can you understand just by looking at the figures and tables? What is the relationship between each figure / table and the text? How do they work together to communicate effectively, to educate and/or convince the reader?

IV. **Helping the Reader:** In looking over the paper as a whole, what moments do you see where the writer is being especially helpful to the reader? What exactly makes these moments helpful?

V. Citation: Where do you see citation employed in your selected paper? In what sections do you not see citations? Does this seem reasonable based on what you think of as the purpose of these sections?

VI. Application to the Data Analysis Project

The project is an analysis write-up with an outline provided for you to work with. We'll look at what material goes where / how to flush out each section next class. For now, think about what you've learned through observing your selected paper through a writing lens, and how you might apply it to a data analysis write-up.

From the discussion today and thinking about your portfolio reflection, what are two aspects of your writing that you'd like to pay special attention to in your write-up for the data analysis project? (This isn't collected, it's just for you, but hopefully you can connect to something you wanted to practice/improve/work on!)